



HOWLING WINDS

A hurricane may be up to 300 miles (500 km) across, and can generate 190 mph (300 km/h) winds that leave a trail of destruction. Once it moves over a large landmass, a hurricane loses the supply of water vapor that fuels it, and it blows itself out.



► WINDSWEPT

A hurricane blows most powerfully over the ocean, and any island lying in its path is hit by the full force of the storm.

FAST FACTS

The Saffir–Simpson scale classifies storms by their wind speed. Hurricane Irene (shown opposite) peaked at Category 3 off the Bahamas in 2011. Six years earlier, Hurricane Katrina reached Category 5 over the Gulf of Mexico before going on to devastate the city of New Orleans.

CATEGORY 1	74–95 mph (119–153 km/h)
CATEGORY 2	96–110 mph (154–177 km/h)
CATEGORY 3	111–129 mph (178–208 km/h)
CATEGORY 4	130–156 mph (209–251 km/h)
CATEGORY 5	more than 157 mph (252 km/h)

DELUGE

Within a few hours, a hurricane can deluge the landscape with more rain than it would normally get in months. The rainwater can overwhelm rivers and trigger flash floods. It may also cause deadly mudslides. This one buried the village of Panabaj in Guatemala when it was hit by Hurricane Stan in 2005.



STORM SURGE

The higher air pressure surrounding a hurricane pushes seawater up in a heap inside the low-pressure storm area. This heaped-up water is known as a storm surge. As a hurricane approaches the coast, the storm surge within it builds up in a colossal wave that sweeps over low-lying land, destroying any buildings in its path.



Before the storm surge



After the storm surge

▲ STORM DESTRUCTION

This neighborhood in Crystal Beach, Texas, was washed away by a storm surge in 2008.